

- If you instead paid just 0.2 per cent in fees (typical of a low-cost ETF), your investment could grow to over \$57 000, with total fees of only around \$2500.

In this case, your investment grew by an extra \$19 000, but you also paid nearly \$12 000 less in fees, that's the power of keeping costs low.

Now, that doesn't mean the cheapest option is always the best. Sometimes you really do get what you pay for, whether that's access to specific investments, additional features or having someone manage it all for you. There's a bit to consider, especially when comparing different types of funds or providers.

The key is awareness. Know what you're paying and why you're paying it. From there, you can make informed decisions that align with your goals, your values, and your comfort level.

Let's get started investing

You've got your first \$1000 ready, you know what you're looking for, and what common traps to avoid. Now what? Let's walk through how to get you from thinking about investing to actually getting started. The last chapter covered all the different ways to invest, here you are going to jump straight to opening an online brokerage account.

1: Open a brokerage account

To invest in shares, ETFs or funds, you need a brokerage account. Think of the share market like any other market; it's a place where people buy and sell things. But instead of buying groceries or clothes, you're buying pieces of companies (shares) or funds.

A brokerage account is basically your online shop for investing. If you've ever bought something online like clothes, shoes or groceries, then you can buy investments online. The only difference? You won't get a package at your front door a few days later — your investments will sit in your portfolio until you decide to sell them.